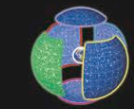


THE CENTAUR

Centaurus



SIZE RANKING 9

BRIGHTEST STARS
 Rigel Kentaurus (α)
 -0.3, Hadar (β) 0.6

GENITIVE Centauri

ABBREVIATION Cen

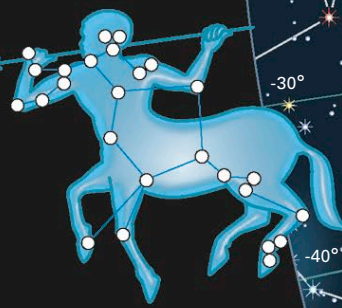
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
 April–June

FULLY VISIBLE
 25°N–90°S


This dominating constellation of the southern skies contains a variety of notable objects, including the closest star to the Sun and a most unusual galaxy. Centaurus represents the centaur Chiron (see panel, right), who had the torso of a man and the four legs of a horse.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Alpha (α) Centauri (see p.252), or Rigel Kentaurus, is a fabulous multiple star. To the naked eye, it is the third-brightest star in the sky. Its system includes two Sun-like stars, which appear so bright because they are only 4.3 light-years away, closer than any other stars bar one—Proxima Centauri (see p.252), which is about 0.1 light-years closer. However, Proxima is of only magnitude 11 and lies four diameters of a full moon away from its brighter companions. Its position means it is outside Alpha's telescopic field of view, so identification is difficult.

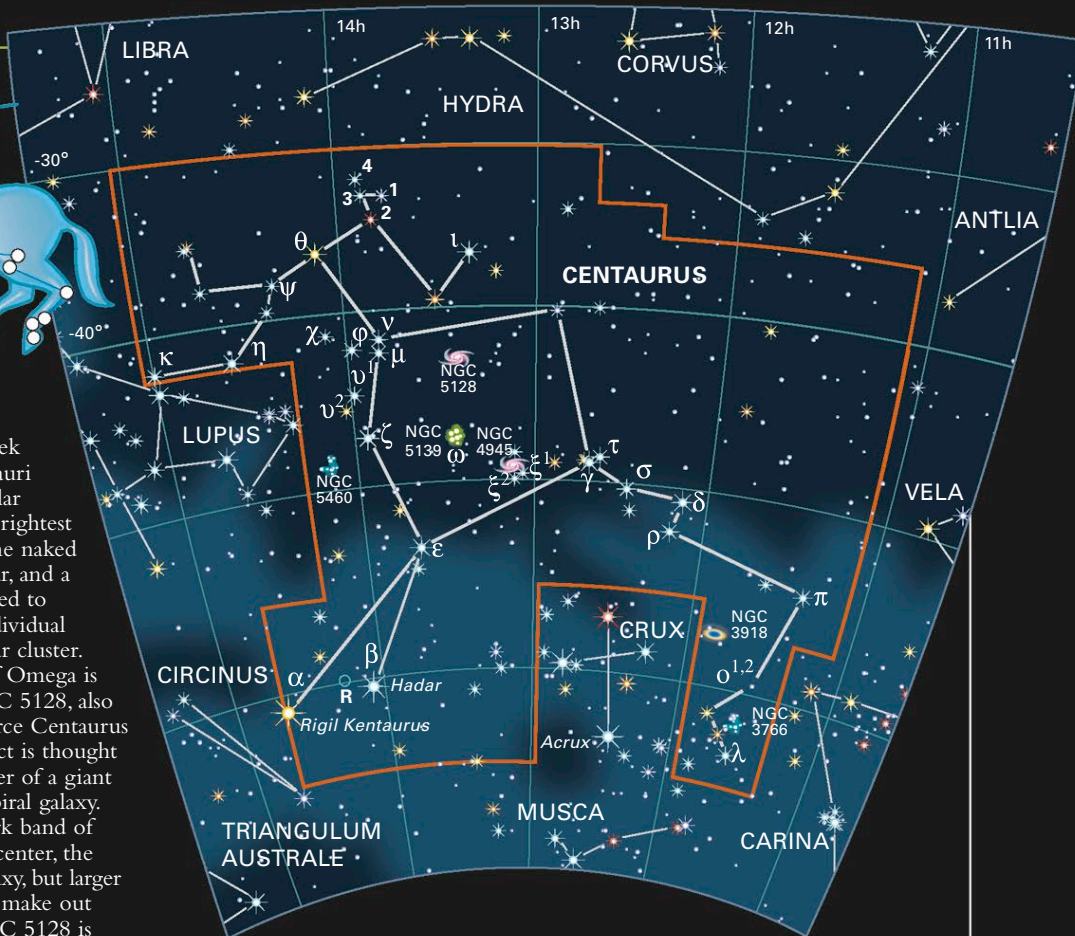


THE CENTAUR

Although it bears a Greek letter, Omega (ω) Centauri is not a star but a globular cluster, the largest and brightest visible from Earth. To the naked eye, it is a large, hazy star, and a small telescope is required to resolve the brightest individual members of this globular cluster.

Almost due north of Omega is the peculiar galaxy NGC 5128, also known as the radio source Centaurus A (see p.322). This object is thought to result from the merger of a giant elliptical galaxy and a spiral galaxy. Photographs show a dark band of dust across the galaxy's center, the remains of the spiral galaxy, but larger apertures are needed to make out this feature visually. NGC 5128 is the brightest galaxy outside the Local Group and, at a distance of about 12 million light-years, is the closest peculiar galaxy to us.

The planetary nebula NGC 3918, or the Blue Planetary, is easily identified through a small telescope. It appears like a larger version of the disk of Uranus. Also in Centaurus are two interesting open star clusters NGC 3766 and NGC 5460.



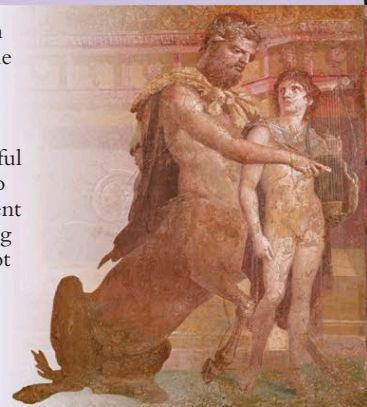
MYTHS AND STORIES

CHIRON

The wise and scholarly centaur Chiron was the offspring of Cronus, king of the Titans, and the sea nymph Philyra. He lived in a cave, from where he taught hunting, medicine, and music to the offspring of the gods. His most successful pupil was Asclepius, son of Apollo, who became the greatest healer of the ancient world. Chiron was immortalized among the stars after Hercules accidentally shot him with a poisoned arrow.

TEACHER OF THE GODS

This Roman fresco shows Chiron teaching Achilles, his foster son, to play the lyre. They are in Chiron's cave on Mount Pelion.



ALPHA CENTAURI ♂

The two yellow stars, of magnitudes 0.0 and 1.3, of this beautiful double star orbit each other every 80 years. They are easily separated through a small telescope.

CELESTIAL CENTAUR ♂

The brilliant stellar pairing of Alpha (α) and (β) Beta Centauri guides the eye to Centaurus, the celestial centaur. The familiar pattern of Crux, the Southern Cross, lies beneath the centaur's body.